If Nikita Khrushchev was worried about his soldiers he had soon cause to worry about his principal comrade-in-arms. Fidel Castro was convinced the US was about to invade. On Thursday, 25 October he gave orders that Cuban anti-aircraft batteries were to fire at low-level reconnaissance jets. On the night of 26 October Castro appeared at the Soviet Embassy in the early hours of the morning, wanting to send a message to Khrushchev. After consuming an unspecified number of beers and sausages, Castro drafted and redrafted a message, aided by Ambassador Alekseev (though without help from a translator). Castro's letter eventually declared:

> If… the imperialists invade Cuba with the goal of occupying it, the danger that the aggressive policy poses for humanity is so great that following that event, the Soviet Union must never allow the circumstances in which the imperialists could launch the first nuclear strike against it.
>
> I tell you this because I believe that the imperialists' aggressiveness is extremely dangerous and if they actually carry out the brutal act of invading Cuba in violation of international law and morality, that would be the moment to eliminate such danger forever through an act of clear and legitimate defence, however harsh and terrible the solution would be, for there is no other.[45]

Perhaps not unreasonably, Khrushchev interpreted Castro's message as a call for a pre-emptive nuclear attack on the United States. Castro was 'a very hot tempered person [who] failed to think through the obvious consequences of a proposal that placed the planet on the brink of extinction,' said the pot calling the kettle black.[46] When Khrushchev replied to Castro on 30 October 1962, he described the proposal as 'incorrect', adding 'we are not struggling against imperialism in order to die.'[47]

Castro argued that Khrushchev had misinterpreted his message, and described the idea that the USSR should be the aggressor as 'immoral and contemptible.'[48] Moscow should not allow its strategic forces to be destroyed by the 'perfidy of the imperialists,' he told Alekseev, in